
PERPETUAL MOTION SQUAD
POCKETEXPENSE+

User Manual

Everything you need to track your money

Purvansh Sahu Yash Arya Aman Anand

APPLICATION	PocketExpense+
PLATFORMS	Android and iOS
TEAM	Perpetual Motion Squad
INSTITUTION	BITS Pilani — BSc (Hons) Computer Science
PROJECT GUIDE	Mr. Murali Raghu
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This manual assumes no technical knowledge. If you can use a messaging app, you can use PocketExpense+.

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1. Welcome

PocketExpense+ helps you understand where your money goes — without the tedium that makes most expense apps get abandoned after a fortnight.

1.1 What makes it different

- **It can log transactions for you.** On Android, the app reads your bank's SMS notifications and records the transaction automatically. For most people this removes the majority of manual entry.
- **It works without internet.** Everything you do — adding, editing, deleting, searching — works whether you are online or not. Your changes are saved on your phone immediately and sent to the server later.
- **It warns you before you overspend, not after.** Set a budget and the app tells you when you are approaching the limit, while you can still do something about it.
- **It explains your spending.** It identifies whether your spending is rising, which categories dominate, how weekends compare to weekdays, and which transactions were unusual.

1.2 Your privacy

Your SMS messages never leave your phone. Everything happens on your device: the text is examined, the amount and merchant are picked out, and the message is discarded. Nothing is uploaded — the app was built without any server that can receive your messages. The feature is off until you turn it on, reads only SMS, and can be switched off at any moment.

2. Getting Started

2.1 Getting the app

PocketExpense+ is distributed directly to you by the developer — it is not sold through an app store. You will receive it one of two ways:

Option A — Expo Go (quickest). Scan the developer's QR code with **Expo Go** (free in the Play Store / App Store). Note: SMS detection and on-device receipt OCR are not available in Expo Go — those need a full build.

Option B — Full build (all features). Open the installation link the developer sent you. On Android, allow "Install unknown apps" when prompted. On iOS, follow the prompts and, if asked, trust the developer under Settings → General → VPN & Device Management.

2.2 Creating your account

1. Tap **Don't have an account?** at the bottom of the login screen.
2. Enter your name, email address, and a password of at least 6 characters.
3. Tap **Create Account**.

You are taken straight to the main screen — there is no email confirmation step. Choose a password you do not use elsewhere; it is stored scrambled, so not even the operators can read it.

2.3 Signing in

1. Enter your email address and password.
2. Tap **Sign In**.

You stay signed in afterwards.

2.4 First-time setup

1. **Set a monthly budget.** Account → Monthly Budget → pencil → enter an amount → Save.
2. **Turn on SMS detection (Android only).** Account → SMS Detection → switch on. See §9.
3. **Choose your appearance.** Account → Appearance → Light, Dark, or Match System.

3. The Home Screen

The home screen is your summary at a glance.

Area	What it shows
Top bar	The month you are viewing, and notifications
Balance card	Total spent this month, and how it compares with last month
Sync indicator	Appears only when offline or when changes are waiting to upload
Spending wallet	Money in minus money out for the month
Recent transactions	Your five most recent entries
+ button	Add a transaction

3.1 The balance card

The large figure is what you have spent this month. Beneath it, a coloured badge compares it with last month:  ↑ **above** = spending more,  ↓ **below** = spending less,  **same** = unchanged.

3.2 Viewing a different month

Tap the date at the top of the screen to switch months — the total, comparison, and recent transactions all update.

3.3 The sync indicator

 **Offline** — no connection (keep using the app).  **Syncing...** — uploading changes.  **3 changes pending** — waiting to upload; it will upload when connected. When everything is up to date, the badge disappears.

4. Managing Your Expenses

4.1 Adding a transaction

1. Tap the **+** button on the home screen.
2. Choose **Expense** or **Income** at the top.
3. Enter the amount, pick a category, add an optional description, choose a payment method, and check the date.
4. Tap **Add Expense**.

The transaction appears immediately, whether or not you are online. If you leave the description blank, the app uses the category name.

4.2 Categories and payment methods

20 categories: Groceries, Travel, Car, Home, Insurance, Education, Marketing, Shopping, Internet, Water, Rent, Gym, Subscription, Vacation, Food, Entertainment, Salary, Freelance, Investment, Other.

6 payment methods: Cash · Credit Card · Debit Card · Bank Transfer · UPI · Other.

4.4 Editing and deleting

Edit: tap any transaction, change what you need, tap **Save Changes**.

Delete: tap the transaction, tap the delete icon, confirm.

4.5 Deleting several at once

1. Go to the **Transactions** tab.
2. Press and hold any transaction — selection mode opens.
3. Tap each additional transaction; the count at the top shows how many are selected.
4. Tap **Delete** and confirm. Tap **Cancel** to leave selection mode.

4.6 Searching and filtering

Search: type in the search box on the Transactions tab. The app searches descriptions and category names. Tap **×** to clear.

Filter	Options
Type	All, Expense only, Income only
Category	Any single category
Date range	From and to dates
Sort	Newest, oldest, highest amount, lowest amount

A red badge on the filter icon shows how many filters are active. Tap **Reset** to clear them.

5. Budgets

5.1 Two kinds of budget

- **Overall monthly budget** — one figure covering everything. Set it under Account → Monthly Budget.
- **Category budgets** — separate limits for individual categories. Set these under Account → Category Budgets.

5.2 Creating a category budget

Go to Account → Category Budgets → tap **+** → choose a category → enter the monthly limit → **Create**.

5.3 Reading the progress bar

Each budget shows a bar:  **Purple** = comfortably within budget ·  **Orange** = approaching the limit (75%+) ·  **Red** = over the limit. Beneath it you see how much you have spent and how much is left.

5.4 Budget alerts

You are notified **at your warning level** (80% by default) and **when you go over** — once per budget per month. Change the warning level to 50%, 75%, 80%, or 90% under Account → Notifications.

5.5 Editing and deleting

Tap a budget to change its amount; tap the delete icon to remove it. Deleting a budget does not delete your transactions.

6. Recurring Transactions

For anything that repeats — rent, a subscription, your salary — set it up once and the app records it for you from then on.

6.1 Setting one up

Add a transaction as normal, switch on **Make this recurring** before saving, choose **Daily**, **Weekly**, or **Monthly**, and tap **Add Expense**.

6.2 What happens next

Daily = every day · Weekly = every 7 days · Monthly = same date each month. New entries are labelled "(recurring)".

6.3 Stopping a recurring transaction

Open the original transaction and switch **Make this recurring** off — entries already created remain, only future ones stop. You will not be charged twice: the app checks before creating each entry and will not duplicate one within the same period.

7. Insights and Analytics

7.1 The Analytics tab

Shows a **monthly summary** (spent, received, difference), a **category breakdown** (largest first), a **daily chart** (spending across the month), and a **six-month trend**.

7.2 Smart Insights

Open Account → Smart Insights for deeper analysis.

- **Spending growth** — month-by-month change over six months, with an average.
- **Top 3 categories** — your three largest spending categories, with totals and averages.
- **Weekday versus weekend** — how your weekend spending compares with weekdays.
- **Unusual spending** — flags transactions that stand out from your normal pattern (up to five, most unusual first).

This is *not* an error report — a flagged transaction simply prompts a second look. Unusual-spending detection needs at least five transactions before it says anything.

8. Scanning Receipts

Photograph a paper receipt and the app fills in the details.

8.1 Scanning

1. Tap **+** to add a transaction, then **Scan a receipt**.
2. Allow camera access the first time.
3. Fit the whole receipt inside the frame and tap the shutter.

8.2 What happens next

The app reads the receipt and fills in the total, shop name, and date. **Always check the amount before saving.** The app tells you how confident it is: "Fields filled from the photo — check them below" means verify and save; "Could not read it clearly. Please enter the amount." means type it yourself.

8.3 Getting better results

Flatten the receipt · good, even light · no shadows · keep the whole receipt in frame · hold steady.

8.4 The photograph

The photo is attached to the transaction and stays on your phone — tap **×** beside the thumbnail to remove it before saving. Automatic reading is not available in every build; if yours lacks it, the photo is still attached and you type the

amount.

9. Automatic SMS Detection (Android)

This is the feature that saves the most effort. Once enabled, most of your transactions record themselves.

Android only. Apple does not allow apps to read SMS on iPhone — this is Apple's decision, not a limitation of the app.

9.1 How it works

When your bank sends a transaction message, the app reads it on your phone, picks out the amount and merchant, and offers to record it. Nothing is sent anywhere. It supports 40+ Indian banks and payment services, including HDFC, SBI, ICICI, Axis, Kotak, Paytm, PhonePe, and Google Pay (Appendix A).

9.2 Accuracy

Tested against a corpus of 200 bank message samples: **99% correctly identified, 0% false alarms, 100% of OTPs ignored, 100% of promotional messages ignored.**

9.3 Turning it on

1. Go to Account → SMS Detection.
2. Switch on **Auto-detect Transactions**.
3. Read the explanation and tap **Allow** when Android asks.

If you decline by mistake, enable it later in your phone's Settings under App permissions.

9.4 Confirming a transaction

When a transaction is detected, a card shows the amount, merchant, and a suggested category. **Confirm** to record it, **Edit** to change anything first, or **Dismiss** to ignore it. If the app is less certain, the card says "Low confidence — please review carefully".

9.5 Logging without asking

Switch on **Log without asking** to record high-confidence transactions silently, with a brief toast:

 Logged ₹450 at Amazon **UNDO**

Tap **UNDO** within six seconds to remove it. Set the confidence bar to **80%, 90%, or 95%** — anything below your setting still asks first.

9.6 Your privacy, in detail

Question	Answer
Are my messages uploaded?	No. Never.
Are they stored on my phone?	No. Read, examined, discarded.
Do they appear in any log?	No.
Can the app read other messages?	It only looks at bank messages. Personal messages are ignored.
Can it read my contacts or calls?	No. It never asks for those permissions.
Can I turn it off?	Yes, at any time. Detection stops and stored fingerprints are cleared.

10. Exporting Your Data

10.1 Exporting

1. Go to Account → Export Data.
2. Choose a period: **This month**, **Last month**, **Last 3 months**, **This year**, or **All time**.
3. Check the summary, then tap **Export as CSV** or **Export as PDF**.
4. Choose where to send it (Email, Files, Drive, and more).

10.2 Which format?

CSV is best for analysis in Excel, Google Sheets, or Numbers; **PDF** is a tidy statement to read, print, or share.

10.3 About the CSV

One row per transaction — date, type, category, description, payment method, amount, recurring flag. Amounts are **signed** (spending negative, income positive), so the column sums to your net position.

11. Notifications

11.1 Two kinds

- **Phone notifications** — appear on your lock screen even when the app is closed.
- **The in-app feed** — keeps a history. Tap the bell on the home screen to open it.

11.2 What you get notified about

⚠ **Budget warning** (you reach your warning level) · 🚫 **Budget exceeded** (you go over) · ⚡ **Transaction logged** (recorded automatically).

11.3 Managing the feed

Tap a notification to mark it read; tap the double-tick to mark all read; tap **Clear all** to empty it. The feed keeps your 50 most recent notifications.

11.4 Settings

Under Account → Notifications: **Budget alerts** (master switch) · **Alert when exceeded** (a second alert when a budget is fully spent) · **Auto-added transactions** (tells you when SMS detection logs something) · **Warn me at** (50%, 75%, 80%, or 90%).

12. Settings and Personalisation

12.1 Your account

Your name and email are shown at the top of the **Account** screen with a letter avatar. Your monthly budget limit is edited on that screen — tap the pencil beside **Monthly Budget**, enter the amount, and tap Save.

Note: in the current version, your name, email address, and password are set at registration and cannot be changed inside the app. If you need an account change, contact the developer.

12.2 Appearance

Account → Appearance: **Match system** (follows your phone), **Light**, or **Dark**. The change is instant; dark mode is easier on the eyes at night and uses less battery on OLED screens.

12.3 Monthly budget

Account → Monthly Budget. Tap the pencil, enter an amount, tap Save.

12.4 Signing out

Account → Log Out. Your data stays safely on the server; signing back in restores everything.

13. Using the App Offline

13.1 What works offline

Everything you do day to day — adding, editing, deleting, searching, filtering, viewing analytics, changing settings — works with no connection at all.

13.2 What needs a connection

Only things that involve the server: signing in on a new phone, creating an account, fetching data onto a newly installed app, and uploading changes so they are backed up.

13.3 How syncing works

Your changes are saved instantly, wait in a queue if you are offline, and upload automatically when a connection returns. The sync indicator disappears once everything is up to date. Pull down on the home screen to force a sync.

If a sync fails, the app retries with longer waits so it does not drain your battery — your data is never lost. On two devices, the most recent version wins, and unsynced changes are kept in preference to the older server copy.

14. Troubleshooting

Problem	Likely cause	What to do
Cannot sign in / "Too many attempts"	Wrong credentials / several failures	Check typos; wait 15 minutes and retry.
Stuck on loading screen	Slow first launch	Force-close and reopen; reinstall if it persists.
Transactions not uploading	No connection	Check the sync badge; pull down to refresh once connected.
Sync badge will not clear	Retry waiting	Pull down on Home to retry immediately.
SMS not working / permission "Blocked"	Permission not granted / declined permanently	Account → SMS Detection, or Phone Settings → Apps → Permissions → SMS → Allow.
Some bank messages missed	Unrecognised format	Add them manually; the app ignores what it cannot read confidently.
Receipt scan reads wrong amount	Poor photo	Retake in better light, flattened. Or type the amount.
Camera will not open	Permission not granted	Phone Settings → Apps → PocketExpense+ → Permissions → Camera.
No budget notifications	Notifications off	Account → Notifications; check phone settings too.
Export does nothing / wrong month's figures	Empty period / month selected	Check the summary; tap the date at the top.
Totals look wrong	Filters still applied	Transactions → Reset in the filter panel.
Dark mode not applying	Set to Match System	Account → Appearance → Dark.
App not opening after install (iOS)	Untrusted developer	Settings → General → VPN & Device Management → trust.

15. Frequently Asked Questions

General

Question	Answer
Is it free?	Yes.
Do I need internet?	Only to create your account and to back up. Everything else works offline.
Which currency?	Indian Rupees (₹).
More than one phone?	Yes — sign in with the same account and data syncs.
Lost my phone?	Anything synced is safe on the server; sign in on a new phone to get it back.

SMS Detection

Question	Answer
Which banks?	Over 40, including HDFC, SBI, ICICI, Axis, Kotak, Paytm, PhonePe, Google Pay (Appendix A).
Why not on iPhone?	Apple does not allow any app to read SMS.
Will it read personal messages?	It only examines bank-looking notifications; nothing is stored or uploaded.
Could it record a non-transaction?	Tested on 200 samples incl. OTPs and adverts — none recorded. If unsure, it ignores.
Why did it miss one?	Some banks use unusual formats; the app ignores what it cannot read confidently.
Is "Log without asking" safe?	Yes — it applies only when near-certain, and every entry can be undone.

Budgets

Question	Answer
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Monthly budget vs category budgets?	The monthly budget covers all spending; category budgets cap individual categories.
When do I get warned?	At 80% by default, changeable to 50%, 75%, or 90%.
Will I be pestered?	No. Once per budget per month.
Do budgets reset each month?	Yes, automatically.

Technical & Account

Question	Answer
Where is my data stored?	On your phone, and on the server once synced.
Is my password secure?	Stored scrambled with a one-way method; nobody can read it back.
Can I get my data out?	Yes — CSV or PDF, any period, from Account → Export Data.
Does it drain battery?	No — it does almost nothing while closed.
Change email / forgot password / delete account?	Not available in the current version — contact the developer.

16. Tips and Best Practices

- **Switch on SMS detection first.** On Android this single change makes the biggest difference.
- **Set a budget in your first week.** Without one the app can only report; with one it can warn.
- **Start with two or three category budgets** — the categories where you actually overspend.
- **Set up recurring transactions once** for rent, subscriptions, and salary.
- **Check Smart Insights monthly, not daily** — trends need time to mean anything.
- **Describe unusual transactions** ("₹4,500 — winter jacket", not "Shopping").
- **Review auto-logged entries weekly;** use bulk delete for mistakes.
- **Export at year end** — keep a CSV or PDF outside the app.

17. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Anomaly	A transaction noticeably larger or smaller than your usual
Auto-add	Recording an SMS transaction without asking you first
Backoff	Waiting progressively longer between retries
Budget	A spending limit for a month, overall or per category
Confidence	How certain the app is that a message is a real transaction
CSV / PDF	Spreadsheet file format / fixed-layout document format
OCR	Reading text from a photograph
OTP	One-Time Password — a login code your bank sends
Pending	Saved on your phone, not yet uploaded
Recurring	A transaction that repeats automatically
Sync	Uploading your changes and fetching others
Tombstone	A marker recording that something was deleted, so it does not come back
UPI	Unified Payments Interface — India's instant payment system